AFFINITY TANKER WEEKLY

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Crude Tanker Comments

VLCCs this week have experienced sharp downward correction off the back of sustained limited activity, although a busier finish ex-Fujairah has given owners some encouragement heading into the weekend. Enquiry built gradually from a quiet start, but for much of the week, a replenishing prompt tonnage list and owners' urgency to secure cover allowed charterers to push rates lower and lower. In the Atlantic, Brazil-East moved from WS 600 to WS 550 on Wednesday and to WS 529 by Thursday; the slowing decline suggests that Atlantic sentiment may be beginning to stabilise.

East of Suez proved harder to read. Fujairah-East fell from WS 650 to a reported WS 550 on Thursday, but today's reported fixtures on subs at between WS 560 and WS 575 – alongside multiple cargoes reportedly working – suggest that some resistance is emerging. Owners East of Suez in position appear inclined to hold back and see how next week develops, with TD34 market indications pointing towards WS 600 and potentially higher moving into the next few days. The week therefore closes with a slightly more balanced tone compared to the rapid softening seen earlier; that said, the tentative bounce in Fujairah has yet to establish a broader recovery. Sustained enquiry and clearer details on the outstanding activity will be needed to show whether owners can build on this firmer finish.

The Suezmax market saw a significant correction at the start of the week, with Atlantic rates resetting as charterers held back and tonnage lists replenished. TD20 was expected to reset below WS 800, and WAFR-Spain and Guyana runs established new benchmarks in the mid-WS 700s. Still, the market held up better than expected, with charterers quietly picking off ships and several fixtures repeating same numbers. By the end of the week, rates seem to have found a floor.

CPC stood out, holding between WS 1,000 and WS 1,100 this week, supported by a tighter tonnage list and a healthy November programme. Its premium over the Atlantic continued to attract owners, although further tonnage could gradually ease the pressure. With Atlantic lists now more balanced and still more enquiry to cover, rates look to likely to hold at current levels in the short term. A busy coming week and any improvement in VLCC activity could provide further support.

Mediterranean Aframax rates began the week on the back of the previous week's sharp correction. Levels stayed highly voyage-dependent, with Libya runs and shorter X-Med voyages commanding a significant premium over Ceyhan runs, while a well-supplied list kept sentiment steady. Midweek fixing cut down both cargo and tonnage lists, firming the tone and, by Thursday, owners had begun to capitalise on this, with WS 760 on subs ex-Ceyhan. With weather set to worsen and neighbouring markets supportive, an uptick in activity pushed the market higher and TD19 ends the week at a new record WS 840.

A dearth of North Sea Aframax activity last week continued into this one, and a long list and soft TD25 sentiment generated soft sentiment. Charterers held back on Monday as they waited to see how significant the inevitable correction would be. When the test finally came midweek, rates fell less than expected, and TD7 earnings exceeded those of TD25; still, rates were highly date-dependent. It seems that a floor was reached on Wednesday, with a tighter list and meaningful interest signalling a possible rebound for end or early dates. TD7 sits at WS 590 on Friday.

Product Tanker Comments

AG LR2 activity returned this week after an absence of meaningful trade during the previous one. An early indication as to rate development came when last week's monstrous WS 725 TC1 deal got failed. Volumes have been intermittent, and in the absence of regular demand, tonnage has replenished somewhat, so owners are having to compete a bit more. Naphtha East was last agreed at WS 535, a fairly significant drop, but LR2 rates naturally had to be re-appraised down to have a chance of competing with the slightly busier LR1s. Westbound rates have not featured publicly this week, but levels could be placed between USD 13.5 Mn and USD 14 Mn for UKC via Suez – quite a muted drop from the last fixture at USD 15 Mn after such a long time of very little activity. There will have been private conversations taking place throughout the week, so it would not be a surprise to see a few ships disappearing off lists over the weekend. Rates should be softer moving forward, but perhaps a floor is not too far off as long as Gulf state oil companies maintain enough throughput on successful shuttling from within the AG. One should be mindful of this when considering the increasing attacks on CPP tankers in the Strait of Hormuz this week.

It was quite the underwhelming week for AG LR1s, with very little activity. The list now looks more populated in the absence of fixing, so sentiment and rumoured rates have naturally slipped, though the hearsay has not been confirmed. TC5 levels have circulated between WS 525 and WS 535, and these are basically the only LR1 rates publicised all week. Although they have not been tested publicly, Westbound rates could now be said to sit around USD 8 Mn basis UKC via Suez. Lower volumes have successfully made it through the Strait of Hormuz, and there are therefore fewer STS transfers taking place. All in all, it has been a very dull week, and the now-longer tonnage list must be cleared before a rebound.

It was another active week for West MRs, partly due to the far more lucrative Handy market which has likely seen multiple stems upsized for more competitive rates. Even now, TC6 pays 30 x WS 535, equivalent to 37 x WS 434 – about 60 points above where X-Med MRs currently pay. Though soaring Handy levels have pushed X-Med and Med-UKC rates higher this week, TA has remained relatively stable, with last done now at 37 x WS 225 after multiple days at WS 220. WAFR has also tested upwards and now assessed at min 37 x WS 350, with Braz higher at the WS 360 mark. Lacking a fresh test, speculation remains about where Med/F East now lies. Via Cape, owners strongly feel freight should begin with a 5, with Suez routing sitting somewhere in the high 4s. Next week, early Nov dates will continue to be worked and, considering we've seen very little quoted in the window thus far, Monday could see an active start after most wait for the list to replenish over the weekend. Sentiment now feels steady here with little downside, and further potential next week if volumes are positive.

A sizzling week on the Handies leaves TC6 trading at approx. 30 x w530, up 60 points from Monday. Activity was steady across Monday/Tuesday, however the majority of stems worked have been prompt and, with the front of the list offering minimal options throughout the week owners have capitalised. Since Wednesday, we have seen volume fall off as MR movements became far more competitive for charterers, though sentiment remained firm and gains were still seen in this period. Today 30 x WS 510 has been subbed on an 05' unit, giving a slight sign of a sentiment dip, though owners will argue levels remain at last done for uncompromised tonnage. Should product continue to be moved on MRs next week, however, Handies may look to be more competitive to secure business whilst returns remain strong.

	BDTI	BCTI
	7171	3014
Δ W-O-W	↓Softer	↑Firmer

BDA

(USD/LDT)	TKR/LRG	TKR/MED	TKR/SML
This week	507.3	515.6	518.9
Δ W-O-W	1.7	1.7	2.4

BALTIC TCE DIRTY

	Route	Qty	$ / Day	W-O-W
TD3C	ME Gulf / China	270,000	1,294,761	↓Softer
TD7	UKC / UKC	80,000	485,769	↑Firmer
TD15	WAF / China	260,000	545,996	↓Softer
TD19	Med / Med	80,000	400,273	↑Firmer
TD20	WAF / Cont	130,000	404,691	↓Softer
TD22	USG / China	270,000	443,298	↓Softer
TD25	USG / Cont	70,000	225,829	↑Firmer
TD26	EC Mex / USG	70,000	250,528	↑Firmer
TD27	Guyana / UKC	130,000	416,875	↓Softer

BALTIC TCE CLEAN

	Route	Qty	$ / Day	W-O-W
TC1	ME Gulf / Japan	75,000	321,900	↑Firmer
TC2	Cont / USAC	37,000	17,647	↑Firmer
TC5	ME Gulf / Japan	55,000	232,035	↑Firmer
TC6	Algeria / EU Med	30,000	110,537	↑Firmer
TC7	Sing. / ECA	30,000	72,545	↑Firmer
TC8	ME Gulf / UKC	65,000	250,792	↑Firmer
TC14	USG / UKC	38,000	64,247	↑Firmer
TC17	ME Gulf / EAFR	35,000	113,387	↑Firmer
TC20	ME Gulf / UKC	90,000	341,933	↑Firmer
TC21	USG / Caribs	38,000	64,418	↑Firmer

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